Electoral Propaganda and Public Opinion Formation in Nigeria's Fourth Republic: A Conceptual Analysis

Isaac Ndubuisi Nwosu, Dimeji-Lamu Michael Tosin, Prof. Adepoju Tejumaiye

Abstract

Electoral propaganda has become a structural feature of democratic competition in Nigeria's Fourth Republic (1999 to present), systematically shaping how citizens perceive candidates, parties, and democratic processes. This paper conceptually examines the relationship between electoral propaganda and public opinion formation in Nigeria, deploying Agenda-Setting Theory, the Propaganda Model, and the Spiral of Silence as an integrated analytical framework. Using a qualitative documentary approach based on the synthesis of scholarly and institutional sources, the study is organised around three thematic concerns: the structural machinery and media dimensions of electoral propaganda; the digital and AI-driven transformation of propaganda practice; and the implications of propaganda-saturated communication environments for democratic consolidation. The analysis demonstrates that electoral propaganda in Nigeria operates through coordinated information management, media capture, digital influence networks, and identity-based emotional appeals, producing public opinion climates that reflect elite preferences rather than deliberative citizen judgment. The findings further indicate that digital platforms, computational propaganda, organised disinformation networks, and emerging artificial intelligence applications have expanded the scale and sophistication of opinion manipulation in contemporary electoral politics. By integrating classical communication theories with emerging scholarship on digital influence, the study contributes a conceptual framework for understanding how propaganda shapes democratic participation and public opinion in Nigeria's Fourth Republic. The paper recommends strengthening media independence, digital platform regulation, information literacy, and fact-checking infrastructure as systemic correctives.

Keywords: Electoral propaganda, Public opinion, Nigeria, Fourth Republic, Political communication, Media framing, Democratic consolidation

Introduction

Elections constitute the most consequential arena of democratic governance, representing the institutionalised mechanism through which citizens exercise sovereign authority and signal policy preferences. Yet elections are also the primary space in which state actors, political parties, and contracted communication networks deploy sophisticated propaganda strategies to shape public opinion in ways that serve strategic rather than deliberative ends (Bernays, 1928; Lasswell, 1927). In contemporary democracies, including emerging ones such as Nigeria, the management of electoral perception has become as politically consequential as the formal conduct of the election itself.

Nigeria's Fourth Republic, inaugurated on 29 May 1999 following the transition from military rule, has provided a sustained democratic context in which electoral propaganda has evolved from rudimentary mass messaging to digitally coordinated influence operations. Across seven general election cycles from 1999 to 2023, successive administrations and opposition formations have employed increasingly refined communication strategies, including mass media campaigns, disinformation, ethno-religious identity appeals, digital astroturfing, and platform-based influence operations. The 2023 presidential election demonstrated the extent to which these strategies have become institutionalised features of electoral competition, with disinformation deployed at scale against candidates, institutions, and the electoral process itself (Madueke and

Enyiazu, 2025; Anaukwu and Obiozo, 2025).

Recent studies suggest that this transformation is not confined to campaign messaging alone but extends to broader processes of public opinion construction. Examining the post-2015 electoral environment, Okolie, Enyiazu and Nnamani (2021) show that propaganda strategies increasingly function as instruments for shaping electoral narratives and legitimising political actors. Scholarship on Nigeria's 2023 elections similarly highlights the growing influence of social media platforms in mediating political information and voter perceptions (Aina & Afolaranmi, 2025). These developments indicate that propaganda has become deeply embedded within contemporary electoral communication processes rather than serving merely as a supplementary campaign tool.

Public opinion, understood as the aggregate of individual attitudes toward matters of public concern, occupies a constitutive role in democratic theory (Lippmann, 1922; Price, 1992). Habermas (1989) locates the legitimacy of democratic governance in the communicative rationality of the public sphere, where opinion formation is expected to occur through open, reasoned, and inclusive deliberation. The empirical reality of electoral communication in Nigeria diverges substantially from this normative ideal. The political communication environment is characterised by unequal information access, media concentration, state interference in broadcasting, digital disinformation, and the systematic mobilisation of propaganda by well-resourced political actors (McNair, 2018).

While the literature has addressed aspects of political communication, media framing, social media influence, and democratic challenges in Nigeria's Fourth Republic, the specific conceptual relationship between electoral propaganda and public opinion formation has received comparatively limited systematic attention. Existing scholarship has generated important empirical insights into campaign communication, electoral behaviour, digital media influence, and propaganda practices in particular election cycles (Okolie et al., 2021; Anaukwu & Obiozo, 2025). Moreover, recent work has increasingly examined the role of social media in shaping political attitudes and electoral outcomes in Nigeria (Aina & Afolaranmi, 2025), while broader analyses have explored the implications of digital communication for public political opinion between 2015 and 2023 (Onwuta, 2026). However, these studies generally focus on specific elections, platforms, or measurable communication effects. Less attention has been devoted to developing a comprehensive conceptual explanation of how electoral propaganda operates as a sustained system of public opinion construction across Nigeria's Fourth Republic. This limitation is particularly significant in contemporary information environments characterised by what Bennett and Livingston (2018) describe as a disinformation order, where political actors increasingly compete to influence public understanding through strategically managed information flows. This paper seeks to address that gap by providing a theoretically grounded examination of how electoral propaganda operates to construct public opinion in Nigeria's democratic context. The study contributes to the political communication literature in Africa by situating electoral propaganda within a theoretically integrated framework that combines Agenda-Setting Theory, the Propaganda Model, and the Spiral of Silence to explain the interaction between media structures, influence strategies, and citizen responses in emerging democracies. It is limited to Nigeria's Fourth Republic from 1999 to the present and employs a conceptual, library-based methodology drawing on peer-reviewed scholarship and credible secondary sources rather than primary data collection.

Specifically, the study pursues three objectives: (i) it examines the structural mechanisms through which electoral propaganda operates in Nigeria's Fourth Republic. (ii) it analyses the role of digital communication technologies and emerging artificial intelligence applications in transforming contemporary propaganda practices. (iii) it evaluates the implications of propaganda-driven public opinion formation for democratic consolidation and civic engagement in Nigeria. Through these objectives, the study provides a holistic account of the evolving relationship between electoral propaganda, media influence, and democratic politics in

contemporary Nigeria.

Theoretical Integration and Discussion

This study is anchored in three complementary theoretical traditions: Agenda-Setting Theory, the Propaganda Model, and the Spiral of Silence. These theories function not as independent frameworks but as analytically integrated lenses that illuminate distinct but interrelated dimensions of the propaganda and public opinion relationship in Nigeria's electoral context. Agenda-Setting operates at the media-public interface, explaining which issues receive salience. The Propaganda Model operates at the structural level, explaining why media systems reproduce elite-serving narratives. The Spiral of Silence operates at the individual and social level, explaining how manufactured opinion climates are internalised and reproduced through conformity dynamics. These perspectives provide a multilevel explanation of propaganda, linking institutional communication structures, media agenda construction, and citizen responses. Their continued relevance is particularly evident in digitally networked communication environments where elite influence increasingly operates through both traditional media institutions and algorithmically mediated platforms (Howard & Woolley, 2016).

Agenda-Setting Theory, developed by McCombs and Shaw (1972) through their landmark study of the 1968 United States presidential election, proposes that mass media exert significant influence over public opinion not by telling people what to think but by shaping which issues and actors receive public attention. The second level of the theory, introduced by McCombs, Shaw and Weaver (1997), focuses on attribute salience, arguing that media influence public perceptions not only by determining which issues become prominent but also by emphasising particular attributes of those issues and political actors In Nigeria's electoral context, second-level agenda-setting is observable in the systematic foregrounding of candidate attributes such as ethnic identity and religious affiliation by state-aligned media, while corruption records and policy failures receive diminished attention. The agenda-setting function thereby serves as a primary vehicle through which electoral propaganda directs public evaluative attention toward propaganda-friendly narratives. In contemporary digital environments, agenda-setting extends beyond conventional news organisations to include social media platforms, influencers, and algorithmic recommendation systems that shape the visibility and circulation of political content. As a result, political actors are increasingly able to influence public salience structures through coordinated online communication strategies that amplify selected issues while marginalising others (Woolley & Howard, 2018).

Attribute framing translates into concrete electoral outcomes through its operation on ethno-regional and religious identity dimensions. Okolie, Enyiazu and Nnamani (2021) document how both major parties in the 2015 presidential election constructed propaganda campaigns around ethnic and religious identity attributes that systematically displaced policy and governance performance as the primary evaluative criteria available to voters. By framing elections as contests between ethnic or religious communities rather than alternative governance programmes, propaganda substitutes identity loyalty for deliberative judgment, producing evaluations that are structurally resistant to counter argument because they are anchored in identity rather than evidence. The persistence of such identity-centred framing demonstrates that agenda-setting effects in Nigeria often operate through culturally resonant narratives that shape not only what citizens think about but also the criteria by which political actors are judged.

Herman and Chomsky's (1988) Propaganda Model identifies five institutional filters through which news content passes before reaching the public: media ownership concentration, dependence on advertising revenue, reliance on elite information sources, flak from powerful interests, and dominant ideological frameworks. Applied to Nigeria's electoral environment, these filters reveal the structural dependencies that render the media system susceptible to propaganda. Nigerian media organisations depend substantially on government advertising revenue, operate within proprietorship structures aligned with partisan interests, and function in a

regulatory environment in which licences and accreditation can be deployed as instruments of pressure (RSF, 2024). These conditions create powerful institutional incentives for media organisations to reproduce propaganda-aligned narratives and disincentivise independent, adversarial electoral journalism. Contemporary developments suggest that these structural filters now extend beyond conventional media organisations. Digital platforms, targeted advertising systems, data analytics, and organised social media manipulation campaigns increasingly function as additional channels through which political actors influence information visibility and narrative dominance (Bradshaw, Bailey, & Howard, 2021; Woolley & Howard, 2018). Rather than replacing Herman and Chomsky's original framework, these developments illustrate how its underlying logic can be adapted to understand propaganda in hybrid media systems characterised by interactions between legacy and digital communication infrastructures.

Noelle-Neumann's (1984) Spiral of Silence Theory explains how propaganda-constructed majority opinion climates suppress public expression of dissenting views. Individuals who perceive their views to be minority positions tend to remain publicly silent out of fear of social isolation and sanction, creating a feedback loop in which the dominant opinion appears to grow ever stronger while dissenting perspectives recede. In Nigeria's electoral context, the spiral mechanism has particular explanatory power. Electoral propaganda is frequently designed not merely to persuade voters but to construct the social perception of overwhelming consensus around a candidate or party. Orchestrated rallies, manufactured endorsements, inflated crowd estimates, fabricated polling results, and coordinated social media endorsements collectively trigger this spiral, creating an information environment in which opposition views appear socially deviant or futile. This mechanism is especially effective in Nigeria's high-context social culture, where public deviance from perceived community consensus carries significant interpersonal costs and where communal identity frameworks tend to override individual political judgment. Social media environments may intensify this process because visible indicators of popularity, including likes, shares, comments, trending topics, and coordinated online endorsements, create powerful signals regarding the perceived distribution of public opinion. These signals can reinforce conformity pressures even when they are artificially generated through organised digital influence operations (Howard & Woolley, 2016).

These three theoretical traditions explain the full arc of propaganda's influence on public opinion: structural filters determine what information enters the public sphere; agenda-setting determines which issues and attributes within that information receive salience; and the spiral of silence determines how citizens respond to the manufactured opinion climates that result. The integrated framework reveals that propaganda in Nigeria does not merely influence pre-existing public opinion but actively constructs the informational and social conditions within which opinion formation occurs, a distinction with significant theoretical and practical implications. Importantly, the emergence of computational propaganda, artificial intelligence-assisted content generation, and organised disinformation networks does not invalidate these theories; rather, it demonstrates their continuing utility in explaining how contemporary technologies amplify long-standing mechanisms of political influence. The digital transformation of propaganda has altered the speed, scale, and precision of opinion manipulation, but its effectiveness continues to depend on agenda control, structural information asymmetries, and perceptions of social consensus.

Methodology

This study uses a qualitative conceptual design based on library-based documentary analysis. Instead of collecting primary data, it interrogates theoretical frameworks to build explanatory accounts of complex social phenomena. The method involves the systematic identification, retrieval, critical evaluation, and thematic synthesis of peer-reviewed journal articles, scholarly books, policy documents, and credible institutional reports relevant to electoral propaganda, political communication, public opinion formation, disinformation, democratic governance, and digital media. The documentary corpus was assembled from academic databases

and scholarly search platforms, with emphasis placed on literature addressing Nigeria's Fourth Republic while also incorporating foundational works and comparative studies that provide theoretical insight into propaganda and opinion formation. The literature matrix therefore combined classical texts in political communication with contemporary scholarship on electoral communication, social media influence, and democratic participation. By adopting a conceptual documentary approach, the study shifts attention from election-specific measurements towards a broader examination of the structural and communicative processes through which propaganda shapes public opinion across successive electoral cycles.

The analysis applies thematic content analysis and conceptual synthesis, adapting Braun and Clarke (2006) framework to conceptual inquiry. Documents were examined for recurring patterns relating to propaganda strategies, media influence, information control, digital disinformation, public opinion formation, civic engagement, and democratic outcomes. Themes were generated both deductively from Agenda-Setting Theory, the Propaganda Model, and the Spiral of Silence, and inductively from patterns that emerged across the reviewed literature. Through iterative comparison and synthesis, related concepts were organised into broader thematic categories that illuminate the structural, technological, and democratic dimensions of electoral propaganda in Nigeria. This approach ensures that the analysis remains theoretically grounded while remaining attentive to the documented realities of Nigeria's evolving electoral communication environment.

Thematic Synthesis of Electoral Propaganda

Structural Machinery and Media Capture

Electoral propaganda in Nigeria's Fourth Republic is not an improvised or incidental feature of democratic competition. It is structurally organised through dedicated party communication apparatuses, government information management infrastructure, and contracted digital influence networks that operate across traditional and social media platforms. Understanding this structural architecture is essential to understanding how propaganda achieves its opinion-constructing effects at electoral scale.

The incumbent advantage in electoral communication represents perhaps the most enduring structural feature of Nigeria's Fourth Republic propaganda environment. State-controlled broadcast institutions have historically provided disproportionately favourable coverage to ruling party candidates, effectively deploying public communication resources as instruments of partisan electoral propaganda. Government information and communication ministries routinely engage in narrative control, strategic framing, press access management, and the coordination of official messaging in ways that systematically blur the boundary between legitimate public information and partisan propaganda. The National Broadcasting Commission (NBC) has been implicated in this dynamic, with its regulatory decisions at times aligning with incumbent political interests rather than public interest broadcasting principles (RSF, 2024). This pattern reflects broader concerns regarding the vulnerability of public communication institutions to political influence, particularly where regulatory autonomy is weak and media accountability mechanisms remain underdeveloped.

The proprietorship model of Nigerian media transforms private broadcasting and press institutions from independent information providers into extensions of partisan communication networks. Media ownership structures are especially consequential during election periods because proprietors frequently possess direct political interests or maintain close relationships with political elites, creating incentives for selective coverage and agenda promotion. In their systematic content analysis of 288 national newspaper editions from the 2019 campaign cycle, Obukoadata, Okon, and Obogo (2024) provide empirical support for this shift. They demonstrate that name-calling and bandwagon techniques were the most heavily deployed propaganda devices, appearing prominently on front and inside pages. These findings validate the propaganda model's predictions regarding elite narrative reproduction while mirroring the classic persuasion strategies detailed by Jowett and O'Donnell (2015). Ultimately, this pervasive coverage confirms that newspaper-based propaganda

operates as a structured, sustained communication strategy rather than an incidental editorial phenomenon.

The dependence of private Nigerian media on government advertising revenue compounds the structural propaganda vulnerability identified by Herman and Chomsky's (1988) Propaganda Model. Beyond advertising dependence, access to political elites, government information channels, and campaign advertising contracts may also shape editorial priorities during election periods, reinforcing incentives to privilege politically dominant narratives over critical scrutiny.

Government advertising budgets, allocated at federal, state, and local levels, function as both reward for favourable editorial treatment and implicit sanction for critical coverage, producing the systematic editorial self-censorship that the Propaganda Model identifies as constitutive of propaganda-susceptible media systems. While the Propaganda Model was developed for advanced capitalist democracies, its analytical core translates effectively to postcolonial contexts where state-media dependencies are more pronounced and institutional checks on media capture correspondingly weaker.

The disinformation supply chain constitutes a further structural component of Nigeria's electoral propaganda machinery. Fabricated content, including false polling figures, manipulated images, fake endorsements, manufactured scandals, and invented policy statements, is produced, packaged to appear credible, and injected into information channels ranging from encrypted WhatsApp group networks to mainstream broadcast media. The effectiveness of such content often derives from its strategic adaptation to existing political grievances, identity affiliations, and public anxieties, enabling propaganda messages to appear plausible even when unsupported by verifiable evidence. Apuke and Omar (2020) characterise this supply chain as a systemic threat to democratic decision-making, noting that the motivations driving fake news production in Nigeria include explicit partisan intent to distort voter choice. In the 2023 election cycle, Anaukwu and Obiozo (2025) document how disinformation campaigns exploited social media platforms to spread false narratives about candidates and voting procedures, contributing to measurable public confusion about the electoral process.

These developments indicate that contemporary electoral propaganda increasingly operates through interconnected media ecosystems in which misinformation can move rapidly between online platforms, interpersonal networks, and traditional news outlets.

Digital and AI-Driven Transformation of Propaganda

The 2015 Nigerian general election marked a structural shift in electoral propaganda practice, as both the ruling Peoples Democratic Party and the opposition All Progressives Congress deployed digital war rooms, paid social media influencers, and WhatsApp chain message campaigns at scale. Okolie, Enyiazu and Nnamani (2021) document how international political consultancy firms were contracted to design and execute propaganda strategies in this election, deploying emotionally charged narratives around corruption, security failure, and human rights abuses to construct evaluative frames favourable to the opposition candidate. The structural normalisation of contracted propaganda services marked a qualitative shift in Nigerian electoral communication, transforming propaganda from an opportunistic campaign tactic into a planned, professionally managed communication function. This professionalisation mirrors a broader international trend towards organised social media manipulation, whereby political actors employ coordinated digital communication networks, influencers, targeted advertising, and automated accounts to shape public discourse (Bradshaw, Bailey, & Howard, 2021).

The 2019 and 2023 election cycles witnessed a significant intensification and sophistication of digital propaganda operations. This development reflects a broader global transition towards what Howard and Woolley (2016) describe as computational propaganda, in which algorithms, automation, and digitally mediated influence systems are deployed to shape online political communication and public opinion at scale.

WhatsApp's encrypted peer-to-peer architecture has emerged as particularly consequential: content circulates through pre-existing social trust networks, acquiring interpersonal credibility endorsement at each transfer point while remaining immune to external fact-checking or platform moderation. The 2023 election also introduced new dimensions of propaganda weaponisation, including the documented deployment of manipulated audio recordings, deepfake videos, and, for the first time in Nigeria's recent electoral history, the co-optation of credible fact-checkers' reputations by political actors seeking to lend authority to propaganda content (Olaniran and Diepeveen, 2023).

The growing role of artificial intelligence in electoral propaganda represents the most significant recent development in this domain. Anaukwu and Obiozo (2025) argue that AI-assisted misinformation, like deepfake content and synthetic political narratives, significantly shaped voter perceptions and amplified false electoral claims during the 2023 presidential election. Jain and Mitra (2025) demonstrate that AI-driven tools including sentiment analysis, deepfakes, and personalised messaging have fundamentally altered the political communication landscape by enabling highly tailored propaganda content at scales previously unachievable. Wack, Ehrett, Linvill and Warren (2025), in a study published in PNAS Nexus, provide direct empirical evidence from a state-backed disinformation campaign that generative AI adoption enabled substantial increases in disinformation production volume without loss of persuasive impact. The Dubawa fact-checking organisation (2025) has documented a trajectory of AI-enhanced electoral propaganda in Nigeria extending into the preparations for the 2027 election cycle, with fabricated video and audio content depicting senior political figures already circulating at scale.

Facebook's micro-targeting architecture enables propaganda to be delivered to highly specific demographic, geographic, and interest-defined audience segments with precision unavailable through broadcast media. Such practices are characteristic of computational propaganda strategies, which combine social media platforms, algorithmic systems, and audience data analytics to influence political attitudes and behaviour with unprecedented precision (Woolley & Howard, 2018). These architectural affordances are deliberately exploited by political actors, and Apuke and Omar (2020) find that citizens relying primarily on social media for political information are measurably more susceptible to propaganda-driven opinion distortion. The broader African context illuminates these dynamics: a comparative analysis of electoral disinformation across Nigeria, Kenya, and South Africa between 2017 and 2023 demonstrates how digital tools including algorithms, deepfakes, and bots have amplified propaganda potential to an unprecedented degree (Alberts, 2025; Woolley & Howard, 2019). In Nigeria's context, where digital platform oversight capacity remains underdeveloped relative to the scale of political disinformation activity, AI-enhanced propaganda presents a particular governance challenge for which the existing regulatory framework offers no meaningful response.

Implications for Democratic Consolidation and Civic Engagement

The systematic operation of electoral propaganda in Nigeria's Fourth Republic carries profound implications for democratic consolidation and civic engagement. Consolidation theory, as articulated by Linz and Stepan (1996), holds that a foundational prerequisite of consolidated democracy is a communication environment enabling citizens to form genuinely informed opinions that translate into meaningful electoral choices. Propaganda-saturated electoral environments systematically subvert this prerequisite by replacing deliberative information with strategically constructed narratives.

In contemporary digital environments, this challenge extends beyond traditional propaganda to include coordinated disinformation campaigns that distort public understanding of political realities and weaken the informational foundations required for democratic participation (Bennett & Livingston, 2018).

Gyimah-Boadi (2015) identifies the manipulation of electoral communication, including propaganda, media capture, and disinformation, as a primary mechanism through which nominally democratic governments erode

substantive democratic quality without formally abandoning democratic procedures. The 2023 Nigerian election provides a concentrated recent illustration of these dynamics. Madueke and Enyiazu (2025) find that INEC's institutional constraints, including corruption, non-adherence to procedural rules, and lack of independence, created conditions in which the manipulation of the information environment around electoral administration compounded pre-existing integrity deficits, with disinformation campaigns exploiting and amplifying institutional vulnerabilities to maximise public confusion and minimise accountability. Bradshaw, Bailey, and Howard (2021) show similar concern on how coordinated digital campaigns can diminish trust in electoral institutions while creating uncertainty about the legitimacy of democratic outcomes.

A corrosive secondary effect of propaganda-saturated environments is the erosion of public trust in democratic institutions and information systems (Bennett & Livingston, 2018). Apuke and Omar (2020) find that repeated exposure to politically motivated disinformation produces not heightened critical discernment but generalised information cynicism, a disposition characterised by wholesale distrust of all political communication. This cynicism is paradoxically functional for propaganda operations because it undermines the credibility of fact-checking and investigative journalism that might otherwise constrain disinformation, creating an epistemic environment in which all claims are treated with equivalent scepticism regardless of their evidential grounding. Howard and Woolley (2016) argue that digital propaganda systems increasingly operate through algorithms, automated accounts, and networked influence structures that amplify selected narratives while obscuring the sources of manipulation. Under such conditions, citizens may find it increasingly difficult to distinguish between authentic political discourse and strategically engineered information flows.

The polarising consequences of identity-based electoral propaganda pose a further structural challenge in Nigeria's context of pronounced ethnic and religious diversity. By activating ethno-religious identity frames as the dominant evaluative lens for electoral competition, propaganda systematically deepens social cleavages that consolidation theory identifies as primary threats to democratic stability. The 2023 Lagos governorship elections illustrate the ongoing potency of this mechanism, with specific narratives deployed to amplify ethnic and political differences that escalated into post-election violence and institutional controversy (Ademosu et al., 2026). Digital communication technologies frequently intensify these dynamics by enabling divisive narratives to circulate rapidly within ideologically homogeneous online networks, thereby reinforcing existing social and political divisions rather than facilitating democratic deliberation (Woolley & Howard, 2018).

The long-term civic engagement implications are equally consequential. Communication environments that consistently construct false realities, suppress critical perspectives, and manufacture social consensus habituate citizens to passive reception of political narratives rather than democratic deliberation. Across successive election cycles, the result is an electorate participating formally in democratic processes while being systematically denied the informational conditions necessary for substantive self-governance. As artificial intelligence tools become increasingly accessible, the capacity to generate persuasive synthetic content at scale may further complicate democratic communication by accelerating the production and circulation of misleading political information (Wack et al., 2025). Strengthening democratic resilience will therefore require not only institutional reform but also sustained investment in media literacy, fact-checking capacity, and transparent regulation of digital political communication.

Conclusion

Electoral propaganda in Nigeria's Fourth Republic constitutes a structurally organised and institutionally embedded system of strategic communication that actively shapes the conditions under which public opinion is formed. Drawing on Agenda-Setting Theory, the Propaganda Model, and the Spiral of Silence, this study demonstrates that propaganda operates through interconnected structural, communicative, and social mechanisms that influence how citizens interpret political realities, evaluate candidates, and participate in

democratic processes. The analysis further shows that the digital transformation of electoral communication has expanded the reach and sophistication of propaganda through social media networks, organised disinformation campaigns, computational propaganda, and emerging artificial intelligence applications. By integrating insights from political communication, democratic theory, and contemporary scholarship on digital influence, the study contributes a conceptual framework for understanding how electoral propaganda continues to shape public opinion and democratic governance across Nigeria's Fourth Republic. The findings suggest the need for a multi-level response involving institutions, media organisations, technology platforms, and citizens. Strengthening the independence and accountability of media regulatory institutions, promoting transparency in digital political communication, supporting fact-checking and disinformation-monitoring initiatives, and expanding media and information literacy programmes are essential for protecting democratic discourse. Given the increasing use of artificial intelligence and digitally mediated influence strategies in electoral politics, future research should continue to examine the implications of computational and AI-enabled propaganda for electoral integrity, civic engagement, and democratic consolidation in Nigeria and other emerging democracies.

References

1. Ademosu, I, Aondover, E. M., Osadolor, B. and Abraham, B (2026) Divisive politics: analysis of ethnic rhetoric and hate speech in the 2023 Lagos Governorship elections. Front. Polit. Sci. 7:1663797. https://doi.org/10.3389/fpos.2025.1663797

2. Aina, O. B., & Afolaranmi, A. O. (2025). Impact of social media on political opinion before and during Nigeria's 2023 election. Innovative Research Journal of Sociology and Humanities, 2(1), 1-7.

3. Alberts, K. (2025). Unravelling the web: exploring the dynamics of online disinformation and its impact on democracy in Africa. Canadian Journal of African Studies / Revue Canadienne Des Études Africaines, 59(2), 333-359. https://doi.org/10.1080/00083968.2025.2491679

4. Anaukwu, N. O., and Obiozo, C. S. (2025). Disinformation and public opinion in the 2023 presidential election in Nigeria: Key lessons and implications. Scholarly Journal of Social Sciences Research, 4(1), 52-70. https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.15111843

5. Apuke, O. D., and Omar, B. (2020). Fake news proliferation in Nigeria: Consequences, motivations, and prevention through awareness strategies. Humanities and Social Sciences Reviews, 8(2), 318-327. https://doi.org/10.18510/hssr.2020.8236

6. Bennett, W. L., and Livingston, S. (2018). The disinformation order: Disruptive communication and the decline of democratic institutions. European Journal of Communication, 33(2), 122-139. https://doi.org/10.1177/0267323118760317

7. Bernays, E. L. (1928). Propaganda. Horace Liveright.

8. Bradshaw, S., Bailey, H., & Howard, P. N. (2021). Industrialized disinformation: 2020 global inventory of organized social media manipulation. Oxford Internet Institute, University of Oxford.

9. Braun, V., and Clarke, V. (2006). Using thematic analysis in psychology. Qualitative Research in Psychology, 3(2), 77-101. https://doi.org/10.1191/1478088706qp063oa

10. Dubawa. (2025). AI-generated disinformation looms ahead of Nigeria's 2027 elections. https://dubawa.org/ai-generated-disinformation-looms-ahead-of-nigerias-2027-elections/

11. Gyimah-Boadi, E. (2015). Africa's waning democratic commitment. Journal of Democracy, 26(1), 101-113.

12. Habermas, J. (1989). The structural transformation of the public sphere (T. Burger, Trans.). MIT Press.

13. Herman, E. S., and Chomsky, N. (1988). Manufacturing consent: The political economy of the mass media. Pantheon Books.

14. Howard, P. N., & Woolley, S. C. (2016). Political communication, computational propaganda, and autonomous agents. International Journal of Communication, 10, 4882-4890.

15. Jain, V., and Mitra, A. (2025). The role of social media and AI in shaping neo-propaganda for populist movements: A global perspective. In A. T. Vieira, A. F. Joaquim, and A. Duarte (Eds.), Digital populism and the use of neo-propaganda and fake news (pp. 63-86). IGI Global Scientific Publishing. https://doi.org/10.4018/979-8-3693-9999-6.ch004

16. Jowett, G. S., and O'Donnell, V. (2015). Propaganda and persuasion (6th ed.). SAGE Publications.

17. Lasswell, H. D. (1927). Propaganda technique in the World War. Knopf.

18. Linz, J. J., and Stepan, A. (1996). Problems of democratic transition and consolidation. Johns Hopkins University Press.

19. Lippmann, W. (1922). Public opinion. Harcourt, Brace.

20. Madueke, O., and Enyiazu, C. (2025). Electoral integrity and election management in Nigeria: The case of the 2023 general election. World Affairs, 188(1), 77-95. https://doi.org/10.1002/waf2.12055

21. McCombs, M. E., and Shaw, D. L. (1972). The agenda-setting function of mass media. Public Opinion Quarterly, 36(2), 176-187. https://doi.org/10.1086/267990

22. McCombs, M. E., Shaw, D. L., and Weaver, D. H. (1997). Communication and democracy: Exploring the intellectual frontiers in agenda-setting theory. Lawrence Erlbaum Associates.

23. McNair, B. (2018). An introduction to political communication (6th ed.). Routledge.

24. Noelle-Neumann, E. (1984). The spiral of silence: Public opinion, our social skin. University of Chicago Press.

25. Obukoadata, P. R., Okon, P. E., and Obogo, L. (2024). Exploration into usage, frequency, and prominence of propaganda devices by political parties in Nigerian newspapers during the 2019 electioneering campaigns. Newspaper Research Journal, 45(1), 90-109. https://doi.org/10.1177/07395329231213035

26. Okolie, A. M., Enyiazu, C., and Nnamani, K. E. (2021). Campaign propaganda, electoral outcome and the dynamics of governance in the post-2015 presidential election in Nigeria. Cogent Social Sciences, 7(1), 1922180. https://doi.org/10.1080/23311886.2021.1922180

27. Olaniran, S., and Diepeveen, S. (2023, February 22). Influencers and incumbency: Digital disinformation and discontent in Nigeria's presidential elections. ODI Global. odi.org https://odi.org/en/insights/influencers-and-incumbency-digital-disinformation-and-discontent-in-nigerias-presidential-elections/

28. Onwuta, S. O. (2026). Social media implications on public political opinions and electoral outcomes in Nigeria: 2015-2023 (Doctoral dissertation, Godfrey Okoye University, Enugu).

29. Price, V. (1992). Public opinion. SAGE Publications.

30. RSF. (2024). Nigeria: Press freedom profile. Reporters Without Borders. https://rsf.org/en/country/nigeria

31. Wack, M., Ehrett, C., Linvill, D., and Warren, P. (2025). Generative propaganda: Evidence of AI's impact from a state-backed disinformation campaign. PNAS Nexus, 4(4), pgaf083. https://doi.org/10.1093/pnasnexus/pgaf083

32. Woolley, S. C., & Howard, P. N. (Eds.). (2018). Computational propaganda: Political parties, politicians, and political manipulation on social media. Oxford University Press. https://doi.org/10.1093/oso/9780190931407.001.0001

33. Woolley, S. C., and Howard, P. N. (Eds.). (2019). Manipulating the public sphere: Political botnets and the manipulation of public opinion. Oxford University Press.